

Starting a conversation with someone you don't know

7 findings · 12-step checklist · 1 myth · 4 sources · cheatgrid.com

For anyone who hesitates before approaching someone new because they expect to be a bother or to come off badly.

THE GOAL

Your job is to make the other person feel noticed, not to sound interesting yourself. Worrying about how you sound is usually what keeps you from noticing them at all.

CHECKLIST

You're near someone you don't know and you're deciding whether to say something.

- ☐ Pick one plain opening line before you walk over, so you're not composing one under pressure.
- ☐ Make eye contact and let your face relax before you say anything.
- ☐ Put your phone away, or at least out of your hand.
- ☐ Pick someone standing alone, or a group standing in a loose, open half circle, not a tight closed one.
- ☐ Open on the moment you're both already in, the line, the wait, the room, not a made-up topic.
- ☐ Ask a plain question with an easy, concrete answer to start.
- ☐ Ask about what they just said before you say anything about yourself.
- ☐ Give them a real reason for saying hello if you have one.
- ☐ Decide your exit line before you start, so you're not stuck once it runs its course.
- ☐ Give a flat first reply one more attempt before you read it as a no.
- ☐ End what you say with something easy for them to answer.
- ☐ Notice whether they turn toward you and keep talking. That already is your answer.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 You read a quiet stranger as someone who doesn't want to talk. That read is wrong far more often than it feels.
- 2 You worry more about their enjoyment than your own.
- 3 Getting turned down when you walk up to someone happens less than it feels like it will.

What you fear, and what turns out to be true

KNOW

You read a quiet stranger as someone who doesn't want to talk. That read is wrong far more often than it feels. Researchers found people make that exact same wrong assumption about others, mistaking quiet for disinterest that usually isn't there. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

You worry more about their enjoyment than your own.

Researchers asking why people avoid strangers found they fear boring the other person more than being bored themselves. [Source 2](#)

DON'T

Don't wait for someone who seems interesting before you say hello. How interesting they seem barely changes how much you'll actually enjoy the conversation.

People in one study were just as happy afterward whether or not they'd picked someone who seemed interesting going in. [Source 4](#)

What tips and one good chat don't fix

DON'T

Don't spend your prep time memorizing better opening lines. The words barely change how the conversation actually goes.

Tested directly, tips made people feel calmer walking in but didn't make them seem more likeable or skilled once talking. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

One good conversation with a stranger leaves you less anxious about the next one, but not by much.

Research found the fear still runs higher afterward than the good experience actually warrants. [Source 2](#)

What actually happens once you do it

KNOW

Getting turned down when you walk up to someone happens less than it feels like it will.

In one study of more than 1,300 real approaches, 87 percent succeeded with the very first stranger they tried. [Source 3](#)

DO

Have a simple way to trade contact details ready when you talk to someone new.

In that same week-long study, about 4 in 10 people ended up exchanging contact information with someone they'd approached. [Source 3](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

Acting more outgoing than you naturally are will feel fake and wear you out.

ACTUALLY

In the study that tested this directly, people who spent a week deliberately acting more talkative and assertive reported no extra discomfort, and their well-being rose instead of dropping. [Source 1](#)

Sources

1. <https://news.ucr.edu/articles/2019/09/16/research-suggests-happiest-introverts-may-be-extraverts>
2. <https://spsp.org/news-center/character-context-blog/why-do-people-avoid-talking-strangers>
3. <https://spsp.org/news/character-and-context-blog/sandstrom-boothby-cooney-talking-to-strangers>
4. <https://www.chicagobooth.edu/review/talk-to-a-stranger-itll-make-you-happier>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Small talk and meeting people at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](https://cheatgrid.com)